# Be the investigator: judge a UFO report

From 1952 to 1969 the US Air Force ran Project Blue Book to look into reports of strange things in the sky. Investigators asked the same questions every time. Use them on the four real cases below. There are no trick questions, and "we don't know" can be a good answer.

> **An investigator's questions**
>
> 1. Who saw it? How many people, and could they be mistaken?
> 2. What was the weather, the light, and the time of day?
> 3. What ordinary things could look like this? (planes, balloons, stars, planets, birds, meteors, animals)
> 4. Is there physical evidence: photos, marks, objects?
> 5. Did anything happen nearby at the same time that could explain it?

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

## Case A The pilot who chased a light

January 7, 1948 · Fort Knox, Kentucky, USA

Highway police called an Army airfield about a huge, round, shining object high in the sky. People in the control tower saw it too and could not say what it was. Four fighter planes went up to look. One pilot, Captain Thomas Mantell, kept climbing after it, higher than 22,000 feet, even though his plane had no oxygen for the pilot. His plane crashed and he was killed. Newspapers asked: what was he chasing?

**Clues to think about**

- Many people saw it from the ground, in daylight.
- It stayed very high and seemed to move slowly.
- Something secret was being tested in the US at that time: giant research balloons that floated very high.

**Evidence that it was something ordinary:**

**Evidence that is hard to explain:**

**Your verdict:** ☐ Explained ☐ Not enough information ☐ Unknown

**Because:**

## Case B The monster on the hill

September 12, 1952 · Flatwoods, West Virginia, USA

Some boys saw a bright light streak across the evening sky and come down on a hill. Seven people climbed up to look. Near the top they saw a pulsing red light. When a flashlight was pointed at it, they said they saw a figure about 10 feet tall with a glowing face inside a pointed hood. It hissed and moved toward them, and everyone ran. The sheriff searched that night and found nothing.

**Clues to think about**

- A bright meteor (a "shooting star") was seen across three states that same evening.
- It was dark and the group was scared.
- Barn owls live in that area. They have round, pale faces, sit in trees, and hiss when they are frightened.

**Evidence that it was something ordinary:**

**Evidence that is hard to explain:**

**Your verdict:** ☐ Explained ☐ Not enough information ☐ Unknown

**Because:**

## Case C Lights over the college town

August 25, 1951 · Lubbock, Texas, USA

Three science professors were sitting in a backyard at night when 20 to 30 soft, glowing lights flew over in a curved line, much faster than a plane. More groups passed by over the next few weeks. The professors tried to measure how high and fast they were. A student took photos of a V-shaped row of lights, and the pictures were printed in newspapers across the country.

**Clues to think about**

- The witnesses were scientists who were careful and honest.
- The town had just put up new, very bright streetlights.
- Flocks of birds called plovers fly over Lubbock at night in late summer.

**Evidence that it was something ordinary:**

**Evidence that is hard to explain:**

**Your verdict:** ☐ Explained ☐ Not enough information ☐ Unknown

**Because:**

### Case D The police officer's landing

April 24, 1964 · Socorro, New Mexico, USA

A police sergeant, Lonnie Zamora, was chasing a speeding car when he heard a roar and saw a flame in the sky. He drove to check and saw a shiny, egg-shaped object in a gully, with two small figures in white beside it. As he got closer it roared, shot out a blue and orange flame and flew away. Other officers came and found burned bushes and marks in the ground.

**Clues to think about**

- There was only one main witness, but he was a respected police officer.
- There were real marks and burned plants.
- A missile test range was not far away. Some people think college students played a trick.

**Evidence that it was something ordinary:**

**Evidence that is hard to explain:**

**Your verdict:** ☐ Explained ☐ Not enough information ☐ Unknown

**Because:**

## Wrap-up

1. Which case was the hardest to decide? Why?

2. Why might honest people see something that isn't what it looks like?

3. What would you need to call a case "solved"?

# Answer key: what the Air Force decided

Teachers: verdicts can differ from the Air Force's and still be good thinking. Give credit for clear reasons tied to the evidence.

### Case A: The pilot who chased a light

Explained (probably)

Project Blue Book decided Captain Mantell was most likely chasing a Navy "Skyhook" balloon, a giant research balloon that was secret at the time. Sunlight shining on a balloon that high can make it glow like a metal object. His plane had no oxygen, so he blacked out as he climbed.

**Big idea:** Something can be real and still not be a spaceship. Secret projects make good UFOs.

Full case and sources: encounteratlas.com/ufo/cases/mantell-1948/

### Case B: The monster on the hill

Explained (mostly)

The Air Force record says the light in the sky was the meteor seen over Maryland, Pennsylvania and West Virginia that night. Later, an investigator suggested the "monster" was a barn owl on a branch, lit up by the flashlight, with leaves below it looking like a body. Not everyone agrees with the owl idea.

**Big idea:** Fear and darkness change what we see. One ordinary thing (a meteor) can start a much bigger story.

Full case and sources: encounteratlas.com/encounters/flatwoods-1952/

### Case C: Lights over the college town

Not settled

Project Blue Book officially left most of the Lubbock sightings as "unknown". The man in charge, Captain Edward Ruppelt, later wrote that he believed the lights were birds reflecting the new streetlights. People still argue about it, and some say the photos do not match birds.

**Big idea:** Smart, honest witnesses can still see something they cannot identify. "Unknown" does not mean "alien". It means "not enough proof either way".

Full case and sources: encounteratlas.com/ufo/cases/lubbock-lights-1951/

### Case D: The police officer's landing

Unknown

Project Blue Book could not identify it and listed it as "unknown". It is one of its most famous unsolved cases. People have suggested a secret test craft, a student hoax, and other ideas, but none has been proven.

**Big idea:** Some cases stay open. A good investigator is comfortable saying "we don't know yet".

Full case and sources: encounteratlas.com/encounters/socorro-zamora-1964/

**More cases, maps and real Air Force files**

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